to demolish the Hatkeshwar overbridge at a bustling traffic junction in Ahmedabad, which was declared unfit for use by an inquiry committee of IIT Roorkee. Four years after it was opened for the public in 2017, the flyover developed four deck settlements and a box settlement, ultimately leading to its closure in June 2022.

The chief minister heads the road and building department, which oversees these projects. Bhupendra Patel has instituted a three-member committee to investigate the Palanpur collapse. But, even before the official probe report was out, finance minister Kanubhai Desai attributed the cause of the collapse to "fabrication workmanship" rather than inferior materials.

Sources within the BJP acknowledge that the issue has rattled the party. Addressing the media after a cabinet meeting, Desai said the government is exploring new policies that prioritise quality over handing contracts to the lowest bidder.

While there is no denying the need for a new standard operating procedure in awarding contracts, demanding quality assurance without considering the lowest cost is just old wine in a more expensive bottle, says the senior urban planner. "The crisis reflects a deep rot in the administrative wing that the government is unable to control," he says. "Undeserving engineers are promoted. Inquiry is invariably done by officers who are part of the problem. No plan is faulty on paper. It is the execution that is full of gaps."

In June, the echoes of the collapse of an under-construction bridge in Bihar's Bhagalpur for a second time reverberated in Gujarat. For, the firm responsible for the bridge, SP Singla Construction, is overseeing two major bridge projects in Gujarat. The Gujarat Metro Rail Corporation has also engaged the firm to construct viaducts and stations in Surat. How many tragedies will it take for governments to blacklist such errant firms? ■



PIPE DREAM Brij Rani, 68, sitting next to an incomplete water pipeline in Bachhechhar Khurd village, Mahoba

UTTAR PRADESH

MAHOBA WAITS FOR WATER

By Prashant Srivastava

At the beginning of November, the Jal Jeevan Mission dashboard indicated glad tidings for Uttar Pradesh's Bundelkhand region. Going by the number of homes with a 'functional household tap connection', the average coverage in Bundelkhand's seven districts—Mahoba, Chitrakoot, Banda, Hamirpur, Jalaun, Jhansi and Lalitpur—stood at 92.6 per cent, compared to 66.9 per cent across the state. Mahoba, located 230 kilometres south of state capital Lucknow, led the success story, with 129,263 of 132,489, or 97.6 per cent of the households covered, up from just 1,612, or 1.2 per cent, when the scheme was launched in 2020.

But go to Mahoba, and the picture is a little different. Raja Bhaiya, a 40-year-old farmer from Bachhechhar Khurd village, had a tap installed at his house a few months ago, but is waiting for water to flow from it. Asharfi Lal, a 57-year-old farmer from the same village, had had a copy of his Aadhaar card taken for documentation by government officials over a year ago, but is still waiting for a tap to be installed